



Illustrations by Annita Soble

The Mega Challah Bake

SOME HALACHIC GUIDELINES¹

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Over the past several months, the Jewish media has repeatedly shared news about large groups of Jewish women convening for the purpose of baking challah. No doubt that these activities are laudable and will, b'ezras Hashem, cause other good developments to emerge. This article, however, comes to address several halachic issues that come to the forefront because of the said group activities.

A Brocha Recited in Vain

There is a specific amount of flour from which, when kneaded into a dough, challah must be separated (henceforth referred to as “shiur challah.” See sidebar for quantities). A dough that was made with less than the shiur challah is exempt from the mitzvah of separating challah. Indeed, if one were to recite the brocha before separating challah from less than a shiur challah, that would be a brocha recited in vain.

1. מאמר זה הופיע תחלה - ביתר פרטים - בקובץ 'העדות וביאורים' גליון א' ע' 81 ואילך.

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She will first recite the brocha and separate challah from the dough, and only then will she distribute smaller amounts of dough to the other participants so that they should shape their own challah-loaves.

Intentions

If one person kneads a large batch of dough with the intention of dividing the entire dough into several smaller batches and distributing them to several people, the obligation to separate challah depends on the following factors:

If each small batch is to be less than the shiur challah, the entire original large batch is exempt of the mitzva of separating challah.²

If, however, the intention is that one of the group will retain a shiur challah for her personal or family use, she is obligated to separate challah from that shiur challah. Furthermore, provided that the other smaller batches were separated from the large original dough before challah was separated from the larger dough, those smaller batches will retain the duty of separating challah from them, too.³

Large Challah-Baking Groups

This leads us to the large challah-baking groups:

1) If each woman

2. שו"ע יו"ד סי' שכו ס"ב. בשו"ת צמח צדק יו"ד סי' רלה ס"א הביא בזה שני הסברים: א) עצם החלוקה היא המפקיעה את חיוב החלה (מקור חיים סי' תנו); ב) הדיעה מראש לחלקה עושה כאילו מתחילה גילוש כל חלק לבדו פחות מכשיעור (שו"ת משאת בנימין סי' א).

3. צמח צדק שם ס"ב. ומברכת כל אחת על ההפרשה מחלקה שהגיע לה - ראה סי' חלת לחם (לכוב תרי"ג) סי' ה' ב'שירי ברכה' סוף סי' ק' לה, הובא בס' לקט העומר (לר"י בלויא ז"ל) פ"ט סוף הע' טו (דף מח), ושם הבין כן גם בדעת הצמח צדק שם.

kneads her own small batch of dough that is less than the shiur challah, she cannot perform the mitzva of separating challah.

2) Even if several women will place their respective small batches of dough into one large container, those batches will not "combine" to comprise a shiur challah.⁴

3) Furthermore, even if one woman was to knead one large batch of dough, her intent to divide this entirely into small amounts will absolve the duty of challah from everyone's small batches.

4) Hence, if the desire is that all participants recite the brocha and fulfil the mitzva of separating challah, it is imperative that one of the group retain a shiur challah for her personal use. By doing so, each of the women in the group will be able to recite the brocha upon separating challah from her own small batch of dough.

5) Point #4 above may give a misleading impression that challah may be separated even if only a small amount of dough was kneaded. **Therefore, the recommended guideline is:**

One woman per group makes a large dough, large enough for her to retain a shiur challah for herself, plus plenty for distribution to other participants. She will first recite the brocha and separate challah from

the dough, and only then will she distribute smaller amounts of dough to the other participants so that they should shape their own challah-loaves.

6) The above may be impractical, considering the logistics of so many women going home with a shiur challah of loaves. As a result, the organizers may be ready to forgo the virtue of each participant doing the mitzvah. They may choose to suffice with giving each participant the physical experience of shaping a pair of challoos, plus, of course, the camaraderie of the event. No brocha would be recited upon separating challah, because none of the women will have their own shiur challah.

7) A possible improvement on the above: One woman in the hall will make a large shiur challah dough for her personal use, while all the other participants will make small amounts of dough. That one woman will be given a lead role and recite the bracha aloud (even over a PA system, if needed) and will separate challah from her dough. The other women in attendance will have had a hands-on experience of challah-making, as well as have been educated as to how to perform the mitzva of challah should they ever make a larger batch of dough for personal use. They will, however, not have fulfilled the mitzva of separating challah.

4. שו"ע יו"ד שם ס"א.

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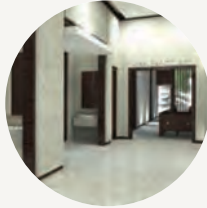
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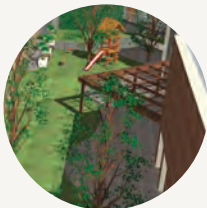
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Kindergartens & Day Camps

Q Each Friday at our kindergarten, one staff member prepares a large batch of challah dough. Each child is then given a small amount of dough from which to shape his or her own loaf of challah to be taken home for Shabbos. Should the staff member be separating challah with a brocha?

A If the children's challah-loaves are baked in an oven on the kindergarten premises, challah must be separated and a brocha recited when doing so. If, however, the children will take their loaves home unbaked, the original dough is exempt of the mitzva of challah.

The ruling for children who are over the age of six is different; here the intended division of the original dough will exempt it from separating challah whether their loaves are to be baked centrally or at the childrens' respective homes (see "Intentions" above).

Quantity for Challah



The quantity to qualify for the mitzvah of separating challah is $\frac{1}{10}$ th of an ephah of flour. The ephah is a measure of volume, not of weight. Hence, the weights stipulated hereunder are given only in order to simplify matters and are approximate.

The poskim are at variance when translating the ephah into contemporary measurements. Consequently, there is:

- a measure that is unanimously accepted
- a measure that is recommended but, due to the doubt, challah is separated without reciting the appropriate brocha
- a measure from which challah is to be separated merely as a chumra.

HoRav Avrohom Chaim Na'eh z"l⁵ rules these measures as follows:

	METRIC VOLUME	METRIC WEIGHT	IMPERIAL WEIGHT
CHALLAH TAKEN WITH A BROCHA	2510 ML.	1666.6 GRAM	3 LB. 10 OZ.
CHALLAH TAKEN WITHOUT A BROCHA	2423 ML.	1615.3 GRAM	3 LB. 9 OZ.
CHALLAH TAKEN MERELY L'CHUMRA	2500 ML. OF LOOSE FLOUR	1230 GRAM	2 LB. 12 OZ.

For a more detailed analysis of the above, see *Spice and Spirit: The Complete Kosher Jewish Cookbook*, p.48 ff.

Other communities require a much larger amount in order to separate challah with a brocha, (i.e. 5 lbs. of flour). Conversely, the prevailing custom in Russia was to measure three liters of flour⁶, which equals about 1230 gram (the smallest amount in the above table). When conducting such events in frum, non-Chabad communities, each community should follow the guidance of its Rabbinic authority. 

5. שיעורי תורה ריש סימן ג (ע' קנה-קסט). ואילו בסדור תהלת ה' השלם (ע' מד) איתא: "הלש עיסה לערך משקל שלש לטרוט מקמח ומים חייב להפריש ממנה חלה". והיינו שיעור 1230 גרם. וראה: יגדיל תורה גי'. חו' כח ע' קמב הע' 19; נתיבים בשדה השליחות ח"א ע' צט; 'על המנהגים ומקורותיהם' (להגר"ט בלוי שליט"א) ע' ריא.

6. כמצויין בסדור תהלת ה' השלם (ע' מד): "הלש עיסה לערך משקל שלש לטרוט מקמח ומים חייב להפריש ממנה חלה". וכן הורה הגר"ז ש"ד דווארקיין ז"ל (קובץ רז"ש ע' 77). וראה הנסמן בהערה הקודמת.